ultimately help achieve lasting peace. However, all suggestions were not followed by any workable plan to initiate and conclude fruitful and meaningful dialogue for lasting peace.

When Mian Nawaz Sharif became the Prime Minister of Pakistan in May 2013, militancy was at its peak in Waziristan and other areas of Pakistan. Depleting economy and rising terrorism were the major problems he was facing. The clarion call was to go after the militants to improve the law and order situation so that the economy could be revived. He surely was determined to improve the economy of the country, but he was reluctant to hit the militants hard through military means. His political rival, Imran Khan, whose party had managed to form government in the province of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP), was also in favour of talks with terrorists. Most of the politicians except the ANP supported the option of talks. Nawaz Sharif decided to give talks a chance. An All Parties Conference (APC) was held to take all political leaders on board. A unanimous decision was made to talk with the terrorists yet once again. However, it was most likely to fail and it did fail miserably.

The timing and approach of negotiations was skewed and untimely. The strategy to talk was based on goodwill only. Real strategy was not chalked out. Plan B was not formulated. There is no doubt that negotiations are an inalienable part of any COIN and CT strategy. However, timing of talks, treaty and truce with terrorists and insurgents are of immense importance. The following yardstick could help decide the timing and approach of talks with terrorists.

LAWS TO TACKLE INSURGENTS AND TERRORISTS

The federal government issued two regulations on 12 July 2011, which provided legal cover to the armed forces for unlawful acts committed during the military operations in both Federally and Provincially Administered Tribal Areas. The two regulations, which are almost identical, were effective from 1 February 2008 to provide legal framework to the military operations conducted in Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) and Provincially Administered Tribal Areas (PATA) since that date.

Under these regulations 'security forces operating in FATA and PATA were given virtually unbridled powers to act as judge, jury and executioner for anyone held on charges of terrorism in the tribal areas' (*The Express Tribune*). They provided a wide range of powers to authorised